

Feelings of Guilt and our Unhappiness in Civilization

In order to make sense of Sigmund Freud's lingering feelings of dissatisfaction, we must first make quantifiable (at least as much as possible) the economics of the psyche. To show how complex this process is, Freud introduces his work with an example. In the first chapter of *Civilization and its Discontents*, he warns his readers to stay clear of false prophets claiming to know what truly matters in life (Freud, 23), because they underestimate the value of things in order to further their own cause of prestige, opulence, and glory. However, relying on such snap judgement is also a mistake in its own right, for the human world and specifically the mental world are multifaceted curiosities.

When speaking to a friend on the treatment of religion as an illusion (Freud, 24), Freud digested what he believed to be the true source of religious sentiments, the starting point for all of society's judgement on religion. To put it haphazardly, the origin is simply a feeling, but it is one he is never without and shared by millions of people, so much so that it can be described as "a sensation of eternity" or an "oceanic" feeling (Freud, 24). While the Church and various religions have seized this oceanic feeling and channeled it into their religious energies, Freud is presented the case by his friend that anyone with this oceanic feeling alone, faithful or not, ought to be considered religious. Strangely enough, Freud claims he cannot experience this oceanic feeling, but whether he's actually the chosen one he proclaims himself to be or merely writing to fuel his own ego, the significance of this feeling stands. For example, where it is difficult to find empirical evidence on feelings, we can attempt to describe their physiological impact and compare symptoms that are bare but traceable. Upon looking for these inklings, Freud falls back on the "ideational content" (Freud, 25). To put it in theatrical terms, it is the advice offered by an eccentric dramatist to the hero who is facing self-inflicted death. The dramatist whispers to the

hero “We cannot fall out of this world” (Freud, 25). There is an inseverable unity with the outside world, and while it isn’t tangible, it is more than a vague intellectual perception.

By introducing this intimation of connection to the world, Freud believes we are directly challenging what we take to be the foundation of psychology (Freud, 26). As a result, he suggests we take a look into psychoanalysis, a more genealogical approach to such a feeling as well as Freud’s own trump card. Under this new view, we must challenge what we take to be the foundations of psychology. Normally, the ego is the most infallible feeling known to man, because there is nothing we are more certain of than our own will. Thus, the ego is seen as something independent and sovereign. We don’t have to give it much thought because our own worries are by default reflected in the ego. However, Freud claims deception and on the contrary, believes the ego to go much deeper into the psyche (Freud, 26). When reflected upon the world, the ego maintains a clear line of division with outside stimuli, but after considering Freud’s psychoanalysis, we can pick out examples from real life which directly challenge these beliefs, Take love, for instance. At the peak of this feeling, when love is in full blossom, the boundary between ego and object is blurred (Freud, 26). A lover will declare that they are “one” with their better half and behave on this newfound emotion. When we believe we have found the right person, the oceanic feeling is finally evoked. A once separate entity can now be considered an extension of ourselves. In fact, the very act of making love is the joining of bodies, which goes into the sexual drives of the id and its correspondence to the ego.

Once we deconstruct what it means genealogically to go through heartbreak, Freud believes we get closer to the answer of unhappiness. To do so, we must examine the oceanic feeling in its earliest rendition, when we seek a return to the unlimited egoism of the newborn, who Freud confidently declares as the most narcissistic being in existence. As a baby, there is no

distinction between subject and object. One simply is and always was the world in its entirety. And so, discontent comes from the realization that at some point, you can't have everything in life. You must distinguish the reality principle with the pleasure principle, and that necessary separation is why there's always a feeling pulling at us from the back of our mind, wanting us to return. The first time we experience heartbreak, then, is when we were children (Freud, 27), because the moment the infant is told their mother can't always be around to breastfeed them is like hitting a wall. We are shocked to have our power taken away so suddenly, then the reality principle slowly takes effect as we get older. Society will not coddle an eight year old to the extent that it coddles a four year old, and it will coddle even less a twelve year old who, by then, we consider to be a teenager. By the time we are young adults, we fully recognize the pleasure principle not as something given or intrinsic, but as a separate feeling we must actively seek out and balance with the various internal and external sensations (Freud, 27). On top of that, we begin to lose the preconceived notion that 'outside' is tied to threatening and 'inside' is indicative of comfort. To elaborate, some of the things that provide pleasure are in fact not ego, but object. For example, the overwhelming majority of entertainment is the result of outside sensation: sports, music, games, interactions at large. On the other hand, some of the sufferings that we seek to shield ourselves from are in fact inseparable from ourselves due to their internal origins.

Eventually, the reality principle dominates our future development. As adults, we are taught to allocate our resources and postpone or completely deny gratification in order to succeed in a long-term goal. To list some examples of passive forms of pleasure: drugs, sleep, gluttony, and sloth all fall under that definition. However, another way to think about pleasure is the "live fast, die young attitude." The need for constant adrenaline and wanting to rush to the top by

taking excessive risks and gambles. Even then, Freud would argue that pleasure derives not in the moment of excitement, but the settling of excitement. So, although pleasure must be avoided necessarily, the body will still do anything in its power to avoid unpleasure, but to the feelings of suffering that come from within, the ego will use the same methods that it already uses for the unpleasure coming from without (Freud, 29). This results in many of the pathological disturbances that Freud observes and the formation of neuroses as symptoms of repression.

With this in mind, it is perhaps better to think about the ego not as simply detaching itself from the external world, but the other way around. At one point, the ego encompassed everything, that was the idea presented by the unlimited egoism of the infant. Later, the external world separated from the ego, so what we carry now is only a shadow of its former self (Freud, 29). In that case, the original contents of the ego would be closer to the ideas of limitlessness and share a bond with the universe, the same connotation brought about by the oceanic feeling. Freud believes we can trace the lineage of whatever survived the transformation of ego, whether in psychology or elsewhere. In the animal kingdom, he cites the crocodile as the connection between the saurian era and the age of mammals (Freud, 30). However, Freud admits the analogy may be a stretch and the real missing link might have gone extinct millions of years ago. Nevertheless, this revelation poses an interesting question for Freud on the human mind, and that is: when did our suffering begin? The problem with answering this question is that preservation in the mind is a subject that's seldom been studied (Freud, 30). Generally, because we have overcome the idea that forgetting something signifies the intentional destruction of that memory, we are inclined to believe that nothing is ever truly forgotten, and if we go back far enough, we'll be able to find the answer to the question. To explain this point, Freud cites the historical example of Rome. A visitor to the Aurelian walls with enough historical and geographical

knowledge may be capable of piecing together the *Roma Quadrata*'s story, even though the city now is nothing but a graveyard for its former self. Obviously, the only way this example relates to mental life is if we picture the Roman architecture as a psychical entity, but even Freud admits there's no real value in entertaining that thought experiment (Freud, 33).

For the sake of the argument, Freud is satisfied with leaving the origins of religion as far as the infantile narcissism, but beyond that he won't examine any further (Freud, 36). Religion is a problem to Freud regardless, because while the rest of secular society suffers in silence, the religious cannot accept the facts of reality. But rather than being condemned as individual madmen, they find each other and look for others with the same refusal. As a result, they build a collective that constantly legitimizes their own alienation, and eventually, they're no longer the alienated ones. By itself, religion is simply one of the defense mechanisms against the three directions of unhappiness (Freud, 44): our own body, the external world, and our relations to other people. It is also in that order that suffering goes from least to greatest according to Freud. First, pain and anxiety from our own bodies are usually indicators of harm or disease, so in a way, they are completely necessary. Second, it is easier to overcome the unhappiness brought about by nature because we can easily dominate nature, though we cannot fully master it. Lastly, social relations are the most unpredictable, so they tend to be more painful to us than any other source. Going back to the example of love, Freud believes we must do our best to bring ourselves closer to happiness by alleviating our burdens. In this case, he suggests we take a look at happiness as an economic problem of libido (Freud, 54). And while he doesn't outright suggest it, the implication is that in order to lessen the toll of heartbreak, we allocate our love as if it were an economic resource. Ultimately, this is just one of countless auxiliaries that Freud believes to be necessary in our confrontation with life (Freud, 44). When dealing with hardship,

disappointment, and impossibility, we make the best of what we have, we release our sorrow through creative expression, and we learn to live alongside our demons. Whether we see Yoga as a path to asceticism through physical motion and concentration (Freud, 36), or we are totally on board with the regression theory and would like nothing more than to withdraw from the world and return to the primordial void (Freud, 27), it is far more important to Freud to try and maximize our livelihood than concern ourselves with equivocal philosophy.